

31338 Network Servers

Lab 2a: System documentation

Aims

1. To be able to use and configure the UNIX manual system
2. To find installed package documentation, and documentation on the Internet

Task 1: Using and configuring man pages

First, start a separate terminal, su to root and run the following command in the background (with the “&”). We will need it later on, but it might take a while to run depending on your system.

```
mandb -cqs &
```

From another terminal, run the following 2 commands:

```
man 1 passwd  
man 5 passwd
```

What is the difference between the two? (Note the answer in your journal). Now run the command:

```
man passwd
```

Which one is shown (section 1 or section 5)?

Look in the file `/etc/man_db.conf`. Look for the `SECTION` entry in the file to verify the above behaviour. While you are in the file, also look at the `MANDATORY_MANPATH` section, to see in which directories the man command will look for man pages by default.

Now run the following two commands and compare them (you might like to run them in two separate terminals):

```
man grep  
info grep
```

Compare the info page to the man page (in general terms) and make notes in your journal. Are they basically the same, or are they quite different?

Finally, check to see if the `mandb` command has finished running (type: “`jobs`”, and see if it is listed). If not, wait for it to finish. The `mandb` command builds an index database of man pages. Normally it is run automatically overnight, but we need to run it manually because the virtual machine is never running overnight! Once it has finished running, try the following commands:

```
whatis passwd  
apropos passwd
```

Which one returns more results? Why? (Hint: read the man pages for “`whatis`” and “`apropos`”).

Task 2: Finding installed package documentation

Installed package documentation is in the directory `/usr/share/doc`. Browse the directory listing to see the available documentation (you don't need to write the list in your journal). To get a feel for what is available, go into the directory

```
/usr/share/doc/sed*/
```

This is documentation for the sed editor. The "*" will depend on the current version of sed installed on your virtual machine. Briefly scan the contents of this directory. You can view the contents of the FAQ file with:

```
zless sedfaq.txt.gz
```

(The `zless` command will uncompress the `.gz` file and pipe it to the "`less`" pager).

Task 3: Finding documentation on the Internet

www.tldp.org (The Linux Documentation Project) is a good place to start for up to date Linux documentation. Use a web browser in the Host OS to carry out this task.

As an exercise in using the site, find the following items on www.tldp.org, and write the URL in your journal:

Find a HOWTO document about the Linux Clock

Find the main Linux FAQ

Find the Linux System Administrator's Guide (or SAG for short)

You might like to bookmark the SAG for future reference in this subject!

Note: for Windows documentation, you have access to Microsoft IT Academy for straightforward reference.